



SMALL-TOWN PARADE

A de Havilland airmail plane, decorated in bunting and streamers, is towed in a small-town parade celebrating the new transcontinental airmail service. During the 1920s, DH-4s like this one made up the bulk of the US Post Office fleet.

after takeoff and finished upside-down in a field a few miles from his point of departure.

After this inauspicious start, the Army did a surprisingly successful job of flying the Washington-to-New York mail for the next three months. The US Post Office was sufficiently impressed to embark on an ambitious plan for a transcontinental airmail service, using its own civilian pilots and specially commissioned aircraft. In 1919 an airmail service was established first from New York to Cleveland and then on to Chicago. The following year it was extended to Omaha, Nebraska, and over the Rocky Mountains to Salt Lake City, then on via Reno, Nevada, to San Francisco.



MAIL PICKUP

A Bellanca CM monoplane is shown in low-level flight picking up a mailbag "on the hoof." Traveling at about 100mph (160kph), the mailbag shock cord can be seen catching on the Bellanca's pole hook.



FIRST MAIL DROP

On September 23, 1911, Earle L. Ovington made America's first airmail delivery, carrying 2,000 letters and postcards from Long Island to Mineola, New York.

LONG-DISTANCE MAIL

This airmail bag, covered in signatures, was carried by Cal Rodgers (see page 47) on his 84-day transcontinental flight across the US from New York to California, started in September 1911.

